

Historical Sites & Preservation

A BRIEF HISTORY OF BEAVER COUNTY

During the 1700's, the area now known as Beaver County was sparsely settled. Both the French and the English came to trade with the Indians at Logstown, an early settlement near the banks of the Ohio River.

In 1753, George Washington was sent to Western Pennsylvania by the Virginia Governor. He came to deliver a warning to the French who had been establishing trading posts and forts in the area, then known as the "Ohio Territory." Washington traveled from Fort Pitt to Fort LeBoeuf near Lake Erie through present-day Beaver County. Washington was not successful in persuading the French to withdraw, and as a result, the French and Indian War broke out shortly thereafter over who would control this territory.

In 1800, Beaver County was established from parts of Allegheny and Washington Counties. Originally, the County was comprised of six townships: Sewickley, South Beaver, North Beaver, Hanover, First Moon and Second Moon Townships. They were divided and redivided over time to make up the fifty-four municipalities that exist today.

Some of the earliest settlers in the area were the Harmonists. This group fled religious persecution in Germany and came to Western Pennsylvania to establish a communal society under their charismatic leader, George Rapp. They settled first in Butler County (Harmony) and then moved west to Indiana (New Harmony), before returning to Western Pennsylvania in 1824. They called their third and final home "Oekonomie," a thriving town that became a center of commerce and industry in the region. The Harmonists continued to expand their economic influence in the County by investing in oil and railroads. They also built the town of Beaver Falls for their industrial operations. However, in the late 1800's, the Society's members began to die off. When the Harmony Society dissolved in 1905, their land was purchased by the forerunner of the American Bridge Company and a new company town sprang up in and around the Harmonist settlement. This town became known as Ambridge.



Photo by Arthur Rothstein, June 1938, reprinted from Ambridge Reprise, <http://wacht.info/ambridge/grapes1.html>

In the nineteenth century, Beaver County played an important role in the "Underground Railroad." This was particularly notable in New Brighton, where a community of Quakers was active in the abolitionist movement. Several members of the Townsend family established safe houses for slaves as they made their way north from the Ohio River towards Canada. The Reverend Arthur Bullus Bradford, the pastor of Mount Pleasant Presbyterian Church in Darlington, preached against slavery throughout the region.

In the twentieth century, Beaver County continued to industrialize due to its location along the Ohio and Beaver Rivers and along major east-west rail lines. In addition, the County was close to coal and other resources that fueled the factories. In particular, steel companies built sprawling mills along the riverbanks.

Beaver County is also the birthplace of the American labor movement. In the 1930's steel workers at the Jones & Laughlin plant in Aliquippa fought with management to establish the 8-hour work day, higher pay, and improved working conditions in the factory. Their efforts to organize are considered the genesis of collective bargaining.

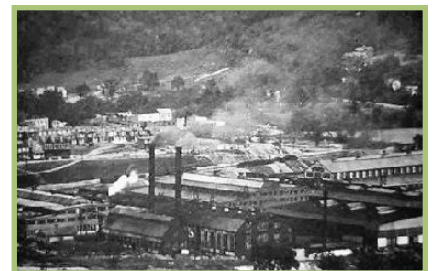


Photo from Bowan archives, reprinted in Ambridge Reprise, <http://wacht.info/ambridge/town1.html>

Steel companies reached their zeniths during and just following the Second World War. However, by the 1970's, production decreased as American steel faced stiff competition from overseas manufacturers. By the 1980's, many of these companies filed for bankruptcy and Beaver County, like other Counties throughout Western Pennsylvania, experienced severe job losses and economic decline.

Today, although many of the steel mills have been razed, Beaver County retains many of its historic buildings and sites. This Section of the comprehensive plan describes those historic assets that contribute to the County's distinct identity.

HISTORIC SITES

The heritage of Beaver County is preserved in many places. Some sites have been nationally recognized. Others are more local in nature. This section provides a summary of some of the more significant historic properties. All resources are depicted on the Cultural and Historic Resources Map.

National Register Historic Districts

Beaver County is fortunate to have three municipalities with designated historic districts listed on the National Register of Historic Places.

➤ Beaver Historic District

The Beaver Historic District in Beaver Borough was designated in 1996 to encompass the original plat laid out by surveyor Daniel Leet in 1792. Beaver represents one of the first "planned communities" in Western Pennsylvania with parcels laid out along a street grid and a system of neighborhood parks. The historic district covers approximately 317 acres bounded by Fair Avenue, Fifth Street, Third Street, Sassafra Lane and the railroad tracks.



The district contains 1,456 historic resources. Most are buildings, but the district also includes military monuments and sites, like Fort McIntosh (described below). The district contains residential and commercial structures, most dating from the late 19th and early 20th centuries. The architectural styles represented include Federal, Greek Revival, Queen Anne and Italianate. The main commercial street, Third Street, is at the center of the district.

➤ Bridgewater Historic District

Also designated in 1996, the Bridgewater Historic District in Bridgewater Borough contains 136 buildings, 97 of which are contributing. The district is generally bounded by Bridge Street, Mulberry Street, Fulton Street, Cherry Alley, Elm Street and the Beaver River. It includes both residential and commercial buildings as well as the lock and dam system of the Beaver Division of the Pennsylvania Canal. Most of the buildings date from 1818 to 1933.

➤ Economy Historic District

The Economy Historic District was designated in 1985. Covering about 32 acres in the Borough of Ambridge, the district includes and surrounds Old Economy Village, a four-acre National Historic Landmark (described below). The district is bounded by the Ohio River Boulevard, 12th Street, Merchant Street and 16th Street.

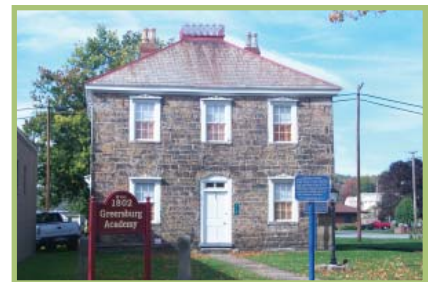
Over 90 original Harmonist houses and well as other buildings and structures are present, most of which date from between 1825 and 1840, when this religious group settled and prospered in the area. Some of the most significant buildings are contained within Old Economy Village, a State-managed historic site. They include the Rapp House, the Granary and the Museum Building and Feast Hall. The most distinctive building, the former Harmonist Church, is located on Church Street across from Old Economy Village. The buildings throughout the district represent a combination of American and German architecture.



Sites Listed on the National Register

Beaver County has 14 buildings, structures and sites listed on the National Register of Historic Places. They are:

- Carnegie Free Library of Beaver Falls – this Classical Revival library building is located in the heart of the Beaver Falls business district. This large and imposing library was designed by F.J. Osterling and constructed in 1899. It was the last of Carnegie’s grand libraries; subsequent buildings were smaller and more modest. The library was listed in 1985.
- James Beach Clow House, North Sewickley Township –The Clow farmhouse was listed due to its architectural significance. Built in 1830, it is one of the few remaining well-preserved homes in the area designed in the Greek Revival style.
- William B. Dunlap Mansion, Bridgewater Borough – this house was built in 1840 in the Greek Revival style. It was owned by William B. Dunlap, former owner of the Ohio River Transportation Company and a Pennsylvania State Senator.
- Fort McIntosh Site, Beaver Borough – the fort was the first one built north of the Ohio River. Constructed sometime between 1778 and 1788, the fort stood on the bluff 130 feet above the river in present day Beaver Borough. Today, nothing remains except a few foundation stones that have been excavated.
- Greensburg Academy, Darlington Borough – Built sometime around 1806, this former school building was founded by the Rev. Thomas Hughes. Several prominent men were educated there, including John Brown, the abolitionist, and John Geary, former Pennsylvania governor.
- B.F. Jones Memorial Library, City of Aliquippa – The library was built in 1927 in memory of B.F. Jones, one of the founders of the Jones & Laughlin Steel Company. The building is an imposing example of the Classical Revival style.
- Legionville, Harmony Township – General Anthony Wayne established the first training camp for troops here in 1792 when he moved his legion from Pittsburgh to Logstown in present day Harmony Township. The site is now an empty lot.



- David Littell House, Hanover Township – The site includes a house as well as several outbuildings. The house was built in 1851 in the Greek Revival style. It was listed due to the integrity of the original architectural features.
- Merrick Art Gallery, New Brighton Borough –Edward Dempster Merrick, an industrialist, purchased the old New Brighton train station in 1880 and converted it into a private art museum to house his art collection. This museum was founded 10 years before the opening of the Carnegie Institute. The train station building dates from around 1850. Merrick added to the building in 1884 and again in 1901. Today, the Merrick Art Gallery remains a museum. It is open to the public free of charge.
- Merrill Lock No. 6, Industry Borough – Constructed between 1892 and 1904, this site consists of three buildings and partial remains of the original lock #6. They are the only remaining lock buildings of the ten that were built to improve river transportation along the Ohio River. The first building is the Power House, a Romanesque structure. The other two, the lockkeepers’ and the crew quarters, also display this architectural style. The Lock was named after Captain Merrill of the Pittsburgh Division of the Army Corps of Engineers.
- P&LE Passenger Station, City of Aliquippa - this station was built in 1910 in the Tudor Revival style. It is one of the later stations built by the P&LE railroad. First called Woodlawn Station, it was later renamed Aliquippa Station. It operated as a train station until 1968 and was subsequently used as office space.
- Raccoon Creek RDA – The park was developed in 1935 by the National Park Service Civilian Conservation Corps as a recreation demonstration area. RDAs were built as part of Franklin Roosevelt’s “New Deal” to serve as organized group camps for underprivileged urban youth. The site consists of numerous camp buildings including cabins, recreation buildings, crafthouses, and the like.
- Captain William Vicary House – this house was built in 1826 by Captain Vicary, a military hero from the War of 1812. As payment for his wartime services, Vicary was given a land grant in Western Pennsylvania. When he came west to claim his land, he built his mansion out of stone quarried on the property. Today, the Vicary Mansion houses the Beaver County Historical Research and Landmarks Foundation.
- Bridge in South Beaver Township – this structure was nominated for listing because of its engineering significance. Built in 1878 by the West Penn Bridge Company, it exhibits a unique form of truss bridge construction.



National Historic Landmarks

In addition, there are three National Historic Landmarks in Beaver County. They are:

- Old Economy Village – this State historic museum site contains 17 original Harmonist buildings dating from 1825 to 1840. Some of the significant buildings include the Museum Building and Feast Hall, the Granary and the Rapp House. The site also contains formal gardens. It is part of the Economy Historic District described above.
- Matthew Stanley Quay House, Beaver Borough – Quay was a political figure in the late 19th century. He served as Republican Party Chairman and Campaign Manager of the Benjamin Harrison



presidential campaign and was elected to the U.S. Senate. He lived in this house in Beaver from 1874 until his death in 1904.

- Beginning Point of the U.S. Public Land Survey, Ohioville Borough – this point was the place where the rectangular land survey was begun in 1785 to survey public lands. This system was used to lay out townships and open up new land to settlement north and west of the Ohio River.

Other Historic Sites

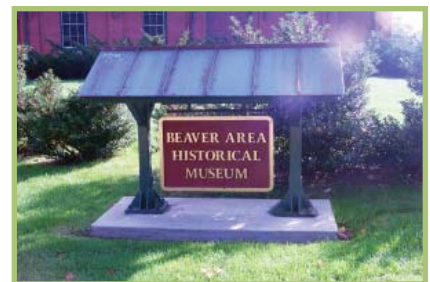
Beaver County has numerous other historic buildings and sites that are not nationally designated. In 1998, the Community Development Program of Beaver County prepared an inventory of historic sites in Beaver County. The report, *Inventory and Assessment of Historic and Heritage Sites, Beaver County, Pennsylvania*, catalogued 296 historic resources that include old homes, churches, cemeteries and other resources.

One such site is Grove Cemetery in New Brighton. Established in 1859, the cemetery contains the graves of several prominent abolitionists as well as several war memorials. It is also a member of the Audubon Cooperative Sanctuary System.

HISTORIC PRESERVATION

Museums and Research Facilities

- Air Heritage Museum, Beaver County Airport – Located in Chippewa Township at the Beaver County Airport, this museum specializes in aircraft and other memorabilia from World War II.
- Baker-Dungan Museum – Situated on the campus of Penn State Beaver, this museum was named for two of the County's earliest settlers. It contains objects, books and documents pertaining to Beaver County history.
- Beaver Area Historical Museum – this small museum is devoted to exhibits pertaining to the history of the Beaver Area. It is located in a renovated, 90-year-old railroad station and 200-year-old log house in Beaver Borough.
- Beaver County Industrial Museum – this museum houses a collection of industrial artifacts and memorabilia from the J&L Steel Company. The museum, which is currently located on the campus of Geneva College, has been seeking a more permanent home. There are discussions about moving the museum to Midland.
- Little Beaver Museum – Another small museum of local history, the Little Beaver Museum contains historic objects and documents donated by local residents. The building, located in Darlington Borough, was built in 1883.
- Old Economy Village – a National Historic Landmark, Old Economy preserves a portion of the Harmonist's third and final home. The four-acre site, which contains 17 original buildings and artifacts, is managed by the Pennsylvania Historical and Museum Commission. A recently-completed Visitor Center contains archives, exhibit space, a small theater, meeting rooms, and a museum store.



- Research Center for Beaver County - The Center is located on the 2nd floor of the Carnegie Free Library in Beaver Falls. It contains reference materials about County history, including genealogical materials.
- Richmond Little Red Schoolhouse – This original one-room schoolhouse was built in 1844 and remained in use until 1950. It is located on Dutch Ridge Road in Brighton Township. It can be toured on Sundays during the summer months.
- South Side Historical Village – This site at the Hookstown Fairgrounds contains several authentic buildings that have been relocated to recreate a representation of early Beaver County village life. The buildings include a restored one-room schoolhouse and a working blacksmith shop. Both are open for tours and demonstrations from April to October.
- Thunder of Protest - Rivers of Steel, a nonprofit organization dedicated to preserving and promoting the Pittsburgh Region’s steel heritage, has self-guided driving tours of Beaver County sites that tell the story of the birth of the American labor movement. The tour, called “Thunder of Protest,” visits sites in Aliquippa, Ambridge, Beaver and Beaver Falls.



Historical Societies

- Beaver County Historical Research and Landmarks Foundation – this organization is located in the Vicary Mansion (described above). It is recognized as the official historical society of the County. According to the foundation’s website, its mission is “the collection, preservation, and interpretation of Beaver County’s historical sites, records and artifacts for the educational benefit of the public.”
- Beaver Falls Historical Society - this is Beaver County’s oldest historical society. It maintains a collection of historical and genealogical information at the Carnegie Free Library in Beaver Falls.
- Little Beaver Historical Society – this group maintains the Greensburg Academy and Little Beaver Museum sites in Darlington Borough.
- Logstown Associates Historical Society – this group maintains an exhibit of Native American artifacts at the Laughlin Memorial Library in Ambridge. It hopes to recreate the Native American trading post at the Logstown site as it was in the late 18th century.
- Model Railroad & Historical Society of Beaver County – Situated in Monaca, this society collects, preserves and exhibits railroad memorabilia, including model railroads.

CULTURAL SITES

In addition to historic assets, Beaver County also possesses cultural resources which enrich the lives of its residents. The following section describes the major cultural sites in the County. Cultural assets are depicted on the Cultural and Historic Resources Map.

- Merrick Art Gallery – this art museum, a national register historic site, houses the private art collection of industrialist, Edward Dempster Merrick. The collection includes works from the Hudson River School and other 19th century painters.

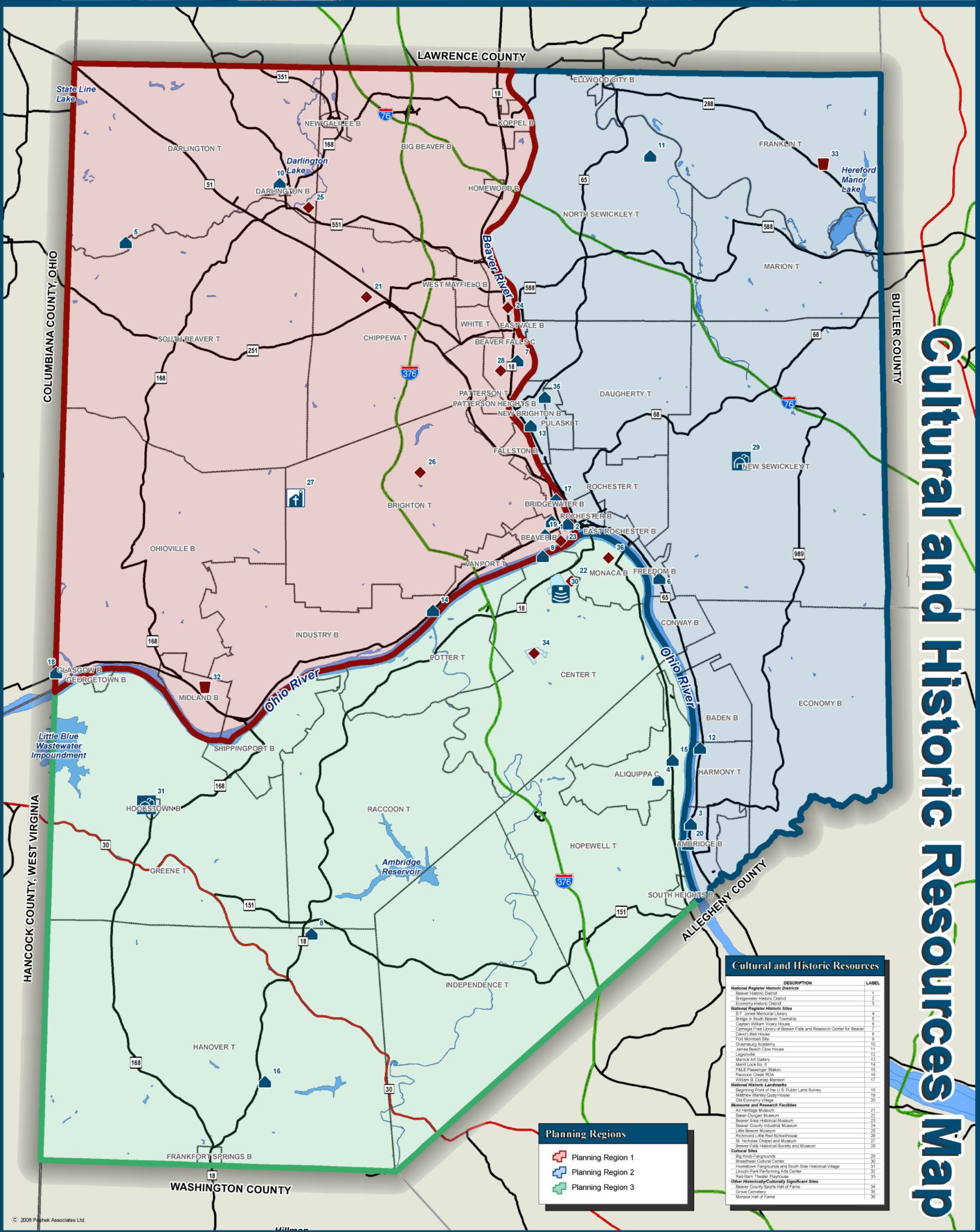


- St. Nicholas Chapel & Museum – This wooden church and museum in Brighton Township was built to replicate a traditional Byzantine Catholic church found in the Carpathian Mountains of Central Europe. It can be toured on weekdays.
- Lincoln Park Performing Arts Center – the center, located in Midland Borough, contains the Lincoln Park Performing Arts Charter School, the Pennsylvania Cyber Charter School, and the Henry Mancini Arts Academy. Classes in voice, acting and dance are offered to the public through the Mancini Academy. The center also provides arts education and other events for the Midland Borough School District. The 122,000 square foot facility includes classroom space, a professional video and audio studio, a 180-seat studio theater, and a 750-seat main stage theatre. The Beaver Valley Philharmonic Orchestra performs at the center. In addition, the center stages several theatrical productions each year including the Tri-State Musical, in which students from Pennsylvania, Ohio, and West Virginia collaborate to perform a Broadway-style musical.
- Brodhead Cultural Center – This Center, located on the campus of Penn State Beaver, holds educational and cultural events that are open to the public. These include concerts, dramatic theater and musicals. Performances are held in the J. P. Giusti Amphitheater which seats 750 people.
- Red Barn Theater Playhouse – Located on Route 288 in Fombell, this theater stages four plays each season between June and September. It has been in operation for over 50 years.
- Hookstown Fairgrounds – the fairgrounds are the site of the annual Hookstown Fair, which takes place every August. Events include livestock and produce judging, performances, a rodeo and contests. In addition, the fairgrounds are home to the South Side Historical Village (described above).
- Big Knob Fairgrounds – located in New Sewickley Township, the fairgrounds are the site of the annual Big Knob Grange Fair. Like the Hookstown Fair, this one is held each August and showcases livestock and farm products. Similarly, there are contests and entertainment. The fairgrounds is also used for other events during the year like tractor pulls and demolition derbies.
- Beaver County Sports Hall of Fame - this museum is located inside the Dome at the Community College of Beaver County. It displays plaques and other memorabilia for 325 local sports personalities. Some of the noteworthy inductees include Joe Namath, Larry Bruno and Mike Ditka.
- Monaca Community Hall of Fame – this facility was established to commemorate residents and industries that played an important part in Monaca’s history. It contains pictures, artifacts and plaques.



SUMMARY OF ISSUES AND NEEDS

- State budget cuts to Old Economy Village have drastically reduced the staff and funds needed to operate this historic landmark site. These cuts threaten the integrity of the historic resources and millions of dollars of State investment in the site over the past decade.
- Historic preservation efforts in Beaver County are fractured. The activities of the various historical societies and preservation organizations need to be better coordinated or even consolidated to create greater efficiency.
- Historic and cultural sites are not sufficiently well marketed within the County and the region as a whole.



Cultural and Historic Resources Map

Cultural and Historic Resources		
DESCRIPTION		LABEL
National Register Historic Districts		
Beaver Historic District		1
Bridgeville Historic District		2
Economy Historic District		3
National Register Historic Sites		
B. F. Jones Memorial Library		4
Bridge in South Beaver Township		5
Captain William Vincy House		6
Carnegie Free Library of Beaver Falls and Research Center for Beaver		7
David Mill House		8
Fort Mifflin Site		9
Greenburg Academy		10
James Beach Cider House		11
Legansville		12
Merrick Art Gallery		13
Merrill Lock No. 6		14
P&LE Passenger Station		15
Raccoon Creek RGA		16
William B. Dunlap Mansion		17
National Historic Landmarks		
Beginning Point of the U.S. Public Land Survey		18
Matthew Stanley Quaker House		19
Old Economy Village		20
Museums and Research Facilities		
Air Heritage Museum		21
Baker-Dunlap Museum		22
Beaver Area Historical Museum		23
Beaver County Industrial Museum		24
Little Beaver Museum		25
Richmond Little Red Schoolhouse		26
St. Nicholas Chapel and Museum		27
Beaver Falls Historical Society and Museum		28
Cultural Sites		
Big Knob Fairgrounds		29
Broadhead Cultural Center		30
Hoodstown Fairgrounds and South Side Historical Village		31
Lincoln Park Performing Arts Center		32
Red Barn Theater Playhouse		33
Other Historically/Culturally Significant Sites		
Beaver County Sports Hall of Fame		34
Crow Cemetery		35
Monaca Hall of Fame		36

Planning Regions

- Planning Region 1
- Planning Region 2
- Planning Region 3



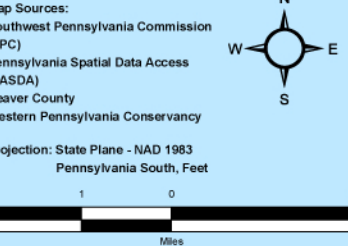
BEAVER COUNTY PLANNING COMMISSION
Beaver County Courthouse
810 Third Street
Beaver, Pa. 15009
Phone: (724) 728-5700
Fax: (724) 775-3915

LEGEND

- County Boundary
- Municipality
- Lake/Reservoir
- River
- Interstate
- US Highway
- State Route
- Historic Site
- Amphitheater
- Chapel
- Courthouse
- Fairgrounds
- Museum / Gallery
- Theater

Map Sources:
Southwest Pennsylvania Commission (SPC)
Pennsylvania Spatial Data Access (PASDA)
Beaver County
Western Pennsylvania Conservancy

Projection: State Plane - NAD 1983
Pennsylvania South, Feet



The preparation of this map was financed in part through a Land Use Planning and Technical Assistance Grant from the Department of Community and Economic Development, as administered by the Governor's Center for Local Government Services, Pennsylvania Department of Community and Economic Development.



PASHEK ASSOCIATES
a pennsylvania corporation